

A

By, on or in + noun

I took his pen **by mistake** [I thought it was my pen].

These shoes are made **by hand** [not using a machine].

I met them **by chance** [it wasn't planned; it was luck].



He broke the plate **by accident** [he did not want or plan to do it].



He broke the plate **on purpose** [he wanted to do it; it was his intention].

My boss is **on the phone** at the moment. [using the phone]

The workers are **on strike** [they refuse to work because of a problem over pay, hours, etc.].

The books were **on display** in the window. [in the window for people to look at]

Part of the building was **on fire** [burning].

Most of the passengers are now **on board** [on the train, boat, plane, etc.].

Why are they always **in a hurry** [needing to do something or go somewhere very quickly]?

I explained everything **in detail** [including all the important information].

She won't make that mistake again **in future**.

The poor little girl was **in tears** [crying].

B

Phrases easily confused

Sometimes two prepositions can be used with the same noun, but the meaning is different.

Lessons begin at 8.30 and the students are usually here **on time** [at 8.30].

If we hurry, we'll be there **in time** [before the time we need to be there].

We were tired of waiting, so **in the end** we went home. [finally, after a lot of time or thought]

At the end of the book they get married. [in the last part]

To be successful **in business** it's important to get on well with people. [working as businesspeople]

They're both in Germany **on business** [they are there for work, not a holiday].

I'm afraid this book's a bit **out-of-date** [old and not useful, or not correct in its information].

I try to keep **up-to-date** with all the changes. [knowing all the most recent ideas and information]

I'll see you **in a moment** [not now, but very soon; *syn* **in a minute**].

I can't speak to you **at the moment** [now; *syn* **right now**].

Common mistakes

I'm busy **at the moment**. (NOT I'm busy ~~in this~~ moment.)

Exercises

78.1 Put the nouns into the correct columns.

board	hand	accident	display	detail
fire	future	mistake	tears	strike

on	in	by
<i>board</i>		

78.2 Choose the correct word to complete the sentences.

- 1 I'm afraid I deleted your email *on / in / by* accident.
- 2 Did she hit him *on / by / in* purpose?
- 3 I just saw them *with / by / on* chance.
- 4 Most of these files are *out-of- / out-from- / out-for-* date.
- 5 My wife is away *in / on / by* business at the moment.
- 6 I'm afraid I'm busy *on / in / at* the moment.
- 7 I've got to go; I'm *in / on / at* a hurry.
- 8 I won't go there again *on / in / at* future.

78.3 Complete the missing noun in these prepositional phrases.

- 1 I saw smoke coming out of the window, and I realised the house was on *fire*.
- 2 Nobody is at the factory. The workers are all on .
- 3 These chocolates are expensive because they are all made by .
- 4 I'm just going to the shop but I'll be back in a .
- 5 I'm sure she broke that vase on ; she never liked it.
- 6 I'm sorry I can't stop to talk now – I'm in a .
- 7 She never thanked me for the present, so I won't buy her another one in .
- 8 You can't trust things you read on the Internet; a lot of the information there is out-of- .
- 9 I told them everything they wanted to know. I explained it all in .
- 10 I went to the exhibition, and some of Katya's paintings were on .
- 11 The manager can't speak to you at the ; I'm afraid she's on the .
- 12 It was a terrible journey but we got there in the .

78.4 Replace the underlined word(s) with a prepositional phrase.

- 1 The meeting was planned for 11 am and we got there at 11 am. *on time*
- 2 Did you get to the cinema before the film started?
- 3 Most of the factory is burning.
- 4 I had great difficulty finding the camera I wanted, so finally I bought one on the Internet.
- 5 He gets killed in the last scene of the film.
- 6 I'm afraid I'm very busy right now.
- 7 I saw her yesterday but we didn't plan to meet.
- 8 I'm writing an email, but I'll be with you very soon.
- 9 Most of these books are old and the information is wrong.
- 10 I explained the system with all the important information.